

NEITHER DID CHIRANJEEVI HEED SAGACIOUS POLITICAL ADVICE NOR DID HE CREATE AN EFFECTIVE PARTY MACHINE. WORSE, HIS PRP FACED ALLEGATIONS OF SELLING PARTY TICKETS.

Andhra Pradesh Human Rights Commission. In implementation, he has banked heavily on government employees, keeping them in good humour with better compensations like dearness allowance and other hikes. Reddy believes an efficient delivery system is the key to success with development initiatives.

Clearly, the choice of contestants and his governance has given Reddy the tactical edge over his rivals. This is also how the party's little known contestant G. Usha Rani humbled megastar Chiranjeevi who promised radical social change through his fledgling Praja Rajyam Party (PRP) which won just 18 seats. Telugu cinema's biggest star hoped to ride to power like N.T. Rama Rao did with the fledgling TDP way back in 1983. Chiranjeevi imagined that he could do it even in the face of formidable opposition—a ruling Congress and a resurgent TDP steered Grand Alliance. The evocative name "Praja Rajyam" (people's rule) and the Obama style promise of change did not click though he had rural crowds greeting him wherever he went.



SUPERSTAR CHIRANJEEVI TURNED OUT TO BE A SUPER FLOP AND LEARNT SOME HARD LESSONS

In the end, he had to bite the dust. The PRP won just 18 of the 294 assembly and none of the 42 Lok Sabha constituencies in which he fielded candidates. The dismal tally is largely his making. Neither did Chiranjeevi heed sagacious political advice nor did he create an effective party machine. Worse, the PRP faced allegations of selling party tickets to cash rich aspirants. Despite the debacle, Chiranjeevi is upbeat. "I will lead the party in the Assembly and prepare it for 2014," says the actor, who had declared earlier that he will not act in films any more. For the moment, however, his is a party of little consequence.

For Naidu, the consolation is in improving his party's strength to keep TDP as a force to reckon with in the state. Though the shrewd Naidu ensured more reliable electoral arithmetic by having the TRS, CPI and CPI(M) as electoral allies, he failed to create the chemistry. The expected transfer of votes did not take place and the Grand Alliance could not present itself as a credible alternative for the cutting edge across the state. They seemed like strange bedfellows which though common in politics who by their discordant voices failed to showcase unity.

Naidu did travel for 117 days on his Mee Kosam

Yatra across the state in 2008 to revitalise his party and build his image. But that apparently was not enough for he failed to convince votes on how he would provide better governance. His desperate promises of a free colour television set for the poor and a cash transfer scheme as another sop did not impress voters. Their apprehensions were that he will renege once in power. Making it worse for him was the ineffective party organisation. It will take a Herculean effort to rejuvenate the TDP and puncture Reddy's confidence.

For Reddy, that confidence can only increase. Since 14 of his cabinet colleagues failed to retain their seats, he can pick from the clutch of new younger legislators to create what possibly is a better performing team. The bigger challenge is in implementing all the promises and the ongoing schemes in the face of a severe fund crunch. But with his party also wielding the reins of power in Delhi, Reddy, after notching the rare distinction of leading the Congress to its second win, can establish firmly that good governance always pays. "My endeavour is to comply with what we have promised in the next four, not five, years," says Reddy. For the moment, however, he can sit back and savour his triumph.